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Tomb, grave

4.8.1 Tomb, grave

References:

Hebrew בַּיִת (bayith) ISA 14:18

Hebrew גָּדִישׁ (gadish) JOB 21:32

Hebrew צְרִיחַ (tsriach) 1SA 13:6

Hebrew קְבוּרָה (qvurah) GEN 35:20, GEN 35:20, GEN 47:30, DEU 34:6, 1SA 10:2, 2KI 9:28, 2KI 21:26, 2KI 23:30, 2CH 26:23, ECC 6:3, ISA 14:20, JER 22:19, EZK 32:23, EZK 32:24

Hebrew קֶבֶר (qever) GEN 23:4, GEN 23:6, GEN 23:6, GEN 23:9, GEN 23:20, GEN 49:30, GEN 50:5, GEN 50:13, EXO 14:11, NUM 19:16, NUM 19:18, JDG 8:32, JDG 16:31, 2SA 2:32, 2SA 3:32, 2SA 4:12, 2SA 17:23, 2SA 19:38, 2SA 21:14, 1KI 13:22, 1KI 13:30, 1KI 13:31, 1KI 14:13, 2KI 13:21, 2KI 22:20, 2KI 23:6, 2KI 23:16, 2KI 23:16, 2KI 23:17, 2CH 16:14, 2CH 21:20, 2CH 24:25, 2CH 28:27, 2CH 32:33, 2CH 34:4, 2CH 34:28, 2CH 35:24, NEH 2:3, NEH 2:5, NEH 3:16, JOB 3:22, JOB 5:26, JOB 10:19, JOB 17:1, JOB 21:32, PSA 5:10, PSA 88:6, PSA 88:12, ISA 14:19, ISA 22:16, ISA 22:16, ISA 53:9, ISA 65:4, JER 5:16, JER 8:1, JER 20:17, JER 26:23, EZK 32:22, EZK 32:23, EZK 32:25, EZK 32:26, EZK 37:12, EZK 37:12, EZK 37:13, EZK 37:13, EZK 39:11, NAM 1:14

Greek μνῆμα (mnēma) MRK 5:5, LUK 8:27, LUK 23:53, LUK 24:1, ACT 2:29, ACT 7:16, REV 11:9

Greek μνημεῖον (mnēmeion) GEN 23:6, GEN 23:6, GEN 23:9, GEN 35:20, GEN 35:20, GEN 49:30, GEN 50:5, GEN 50:13, ISA 22:16, ISA 22:16, ISA 26:19, EZK 39:11, MAT 8:28, MAT 23:29, MAT 27:52, MAT 27:53, MAT 27:60, MAT 27:60, MAT 28:8, MRK 5:2, MRK 6:29, MRK 15:46, MRK 15:46, MRK 16:2, MRK 16:3, MRK 16:5, MRK 16:8, LUK 11:44, LUK 11:47, LUK 23:55, LUK 24:2, LUK 24:9, LUK 24:12, LUK 24:22, LUK 24:24, JHN 5:28, JHN 11:17, JHN 11:31, JHN 11:38, JHN 12:17, JHN 19:41, JHN 19:42, JHN 20:1, JHN 20:1, JHN 20:2, JHN 20:3, JHN 20:4, JHN 20:6, JHN 20:8, JHN 20:11, JHN 20:11, ACT 13:29, WIS 10:7

Greek τάφος (tafos) MAT 23:27, MAT 23:29, MAT 27:61, MAT 27:64, MAT 27:66, MAT 28:1, ROM 3:13, TOB 4:4, TOB 4:17, TOB 6:15, TOB 8:10, TOB 8:18, WIS 19:3, SIR 30:18, 1MA 2:70, 1MA 9:19, 1MA 13:27, 1MA 13:30, 2MA 5:10, 2MA 12:39, 3MA 6:31, 1ES 1:29

Latin monumentum 2ES 2:16

Latin sepulchrum 2ES 2:23, 2ES 5:35

Description and usage:

Tomb with niches, with wall painting of man playing a flute and woman playing a harp (Beit Guvrin) (© Carole Raddato from FRANKFURT, Germany, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The tomb was a construction for the burial of the dead. Since much of the land of Israel, especially in the hilly regions, has little topsoil, tombs were often hewn out of bedrock. In some cases natural caves were used for burial. The entrance to a tomb was closed with a stone (see 4.8.1.1 Stone for closing a tomb<REALIA:4.8.1.1>).

Translation:

Death is a universal experience, and all languages and cultures have words to express the disposal of a dead body. In a number of languages it is important to distinguish clearly between a grave (a hole in the ground in which a corpse is placed) and a tomb (a construction built above the surface of the ground for housing one or more corpses). In some contexts, however, it may be better to use a more generic expression, for example, "places where people are buried" or "places where corpses are placed."

In some passages the word "grave" is used as a symbol for death. Translators should consider whether the physical burial place is in focus or rather the fact that a person has died. In the latter case, it may be better to use a term indicating "death." This will be true especially in poetic passages. For example, JOB 3:22 is literally "who rejoicing unto joy are glad when they find a grave," but GNT has "They are not happy till they are dead and buried." JOB 5:26 is literally "You will come to the grave at an old age," but GNT says "you will live to a ripe old age."

Certain verses speak of "graves" in the plural. Here it will often be appropriate to use a word like "graveyard" (GNT in JOB 21:32) or "cemetery."

In the upper levels of Israelite society burial was often done in two stages. In the first stage the body was either laid on a kind of shelf inside a burial chamber or it was placed in a large box called a sarcophagus ("flesh eater") in English. After about a year, when the flesh had rotted, the bones were moved to a designated place in the chamber. By New Testament times the bones were being placed into an ossuary ("bone box"). These practices gave rise to two expressions in the Hebrew language:

"he lay down with his fathers" and "he was gathered to his fathers." In 2CH 16:14, the place where the body was laid out (*mishkav* in Hebrew) is referred to in the burial of King Asa of Judah. Some translations render the word as "bier" (RSV, NIV; see 4.8.4 Bier, coffin<REALIA:4.8.4>), but the structure of the verse indicates that Asa's body was taken into the tomb and laid in its permanent place, that is, on a shelf in the tomb. The rendering of NJPSV gives the sense better with "resting-place."

1SA 13:6: The meaning of the Hebrew word *tsrichim* in this verse is uncertain. Some versions understand it to mean "tombs" (RSV, CEV, GECL, ITCL). These would be cave-like structures hewn out of the rock. Others use a more generic term, such as "pits" (GNT, NIV) or "vaults" (NJB). Some have thought this word is related to a Hebrew word meaning "stronghold" or "tower" in JDG 9:46, JDG 9:49, but this meaning does not seem to fit the context here.

In MAT 23:29 the Greek word *mnēmeion* may also be understood as referring to monuments built as memorials to people who have died. Here it may be translated "monuments to the dead." This is also its meaning in LUK 11:47. The Latin word *monumentum* in 2ES 2:16 may be understood in the same way.

In MRK 5:2 it is important to avoid a term that would designate merely graves, for the demoniac who met Jesus was not living down in graves in the ground, but had found some habitation either in burial caves or in tombs constructed above ground.